

11+ English Assessment Paper

Section 1a: Reading Comprehension

Below you will find an interpretation of 'The Story of Momotaro', which is a Japanese folk tale.

Read the text and answer the questions that follow.

Momotaro

An old woman made her way down the worn path to the river's edge. Despite the heavy basket of clothes on her back, she quickly navigated to her usual spot and began the job of swirling, scrubbing, rinsing and wringing. Suddenly, a strange sight caught her eye: from upstream, a giant peach was travelling down the river.

Thinking fast, the woman stretched out and scooped the peach into her basket. It was a tight fit but, with the damp clothes obscuring it from view, the woman and her treasure made their way up the path.

Safely home, she unpacked the remarkable peach and placed it on the kitchen table. When her husband finally arrived, they both marvelled at the fruit for some time before eventually deciding to find out whether it tasted as good as it looked.

Taking a large knife from the kitchen drawer, the old woman began to gingerly cut through the flesh.

However, when the peach let out a cry, she jumped back in shock. Slowly peeking through the small gap that the knife had made, the couple saw something miraculous: nestled in the centre — where the stone should have been — was a beautiful, healthy baby boy. The couple carefully opened up the peach and cradled the child.

"We shall name him Momotaro," announced the old man. "We shall love him and raise him as if he were our own child." True to their word, the couple ensured that Momotaro had everything that he could ever need. The old man's teachings sated his thirst for knowledge and the old woman's delicious cooking satisfied his hunger.

Many years later, while the inhabitants slept, a group of ogres stormed Momotaro's village and stole every piece of treasure that they could find. Desperate to help, Momotaro vowed to track down the ogres and return the treasure. Supportive of their son's decision, the old couple

wished Momotaro good luck and sent him away with a bundle of his favourite food: millet dumplings. Not long into his journey, Momotaro was approached by a large dog.

"Can I have one of those dumplings?" the dog asked enthusiastically.

"Of course," replied Momotaro and he threw a dumpling towards the dog, who wolfed it down in one bite. After inquiring about where Momotaro was heading, the dog offered to accompany him on his quest. Momotaro and the dog continued along the path until they were interrupted by a monkey.

"Hey! Those dumplings look tasty — can I have one?" pestered the monkey.

"Of course," replied Momotaro, passing a dumpling to the monkey. With a full mouth, it asked where the two were heading. Momotaro explained and the monkey decided to join them.

As the three adventurers neared the ogres' hideout, a pheasant stopped on the path ahead.

"May I have a small piece of that dumpling?" questioned the pheasant. "I've not eaten all day and they look mightily tasty." Unable to disagree, Momotaro tore off a small piece of dumpling and left it on the ground for the pheasant. After a short while, the pheasant offered to join the group and they continued towards the ogres' lair.

Reaching the large, ornate gates that guarded the entrance to the ogres' land, Momotaro and the animals began to silently enact their plan.

Flying up high, the pheasant scouted the area. Making two quick loops in the sky, the bird signalled that the coast was clear. Then, the monkey scaled the closest wall and dropped down quietly before opening the gates from the inside. Safely inside, it was clear that the ogres were fast asleep. With the dog standing by in case of trouble, Momotaro swiftly tied thick ropes around each of the beasts. When the final knot had been tied, the ogres began to stir.

Immediately, it was clear that the ropes were going to hold for, thrash as they might, the ogres were unable to get free. Conceding defeat, the grotesque creatures turned to Momotaro and begged to be released. "I will give you back your freedom," began Momotaro, "in exchange for your treasure and the promise that you will never harm another human." Reluctantly, the ogres agreed.

Laden with treasure, Momotaro made his way back home. Arriving at the village, he was welcomed with cheers of delight, open arms and a plate of his favourite millet dumplings!

Questions

1. Why was the old woman initially by the river edge?

2. Give **three** words from the text that suggest that the woman sees the peach as special.

3. How do you think the old woman and old man felt about Momotaro's decision to search for the stolen treasure?

4. Explain the role of the dog, the monkey and the pheasant in the execution of the plan to retrieve the stolen treasure.

5. Out of all of the characters, whose role is the most pivotal in the plan to retrieve the stolen treasure? Explain your answer.

6. How does the author portray Momotaro?

Use **two** examples from the text to support your answer.

7. If you could change the ending of this story, how would you change it and why?

Section 1b: Language Analysis

1. Define the following words from the text.

a. wolfed

b. scouted

c. scaled

d. ornate

e. inhabitants

2. What image is the author trying to portray with the words '**began to gingerly cut through the flesh**'?

3. Which adjective is used to describe the ogres?

4. Provide a synonym for the following words from the text.

a. wringing

b. miraculous

c. sated

d. enthusiastically

e. conceding

5. How many times is direct speech used in the text?
